

THIN AND LIGHT CATEGORY

Thin and light, as the name suggests, is the category hosting laptops that have struck a fine balance between computing power and usability, while keeping in mind mobility. The critical parameters that include any notebook into this category are thickness and the weight. Since Intel's Centrino platform promises these parameters, apart from a better battery life, most Centrino-based notebooks fall into this category. Their thickness ranges from 2.5 cm to 3 cm, and the weight ranges from 2 Kg to 3 Kg.

These laptops pack good performance, and if supplement-

ACi Centrino

Too hot to handle

The ACi Centrino is a stern looking laptop with a leather upholstery finish on the top panel. At 32 mm, it was the thickest model, but weighed less than the Acer and BPL laptops, tipping the scales at 2.5 Kgs.

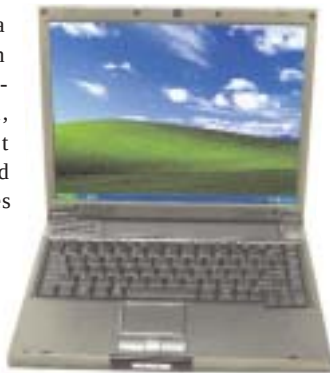
The ACi Centrino packs in an Intel Pentium M 1.7 GHz processor, 512 MB of DDR RAM, a 40 GB hard drive and a 14-inch TFT LCD. The integrated Web cam is useful for video-conferencing. However, the video looks quite dark and image quality is strictly okay.



Ergonomically, the keyboard can do with slightly bigger keys. The small touch pad is highly accurate in pinpointing. Though the two scroll buttons serve their purpose, a scroll pad would have been of great help.

It performed better than the rest, due to its higher clocked processor and 512 MB of RAM. The Business Winstone tests saw it finish ahead of the IBM T40 and the Acer TravelMate 290 by 3 units. Strangely, SiSoft Sandra continuously failed to show the Dhrystone value properly, and returned a very low score. The accolades for the marvellous Whetstone values should be given to its processor. Overall, the system performed perfectly as a whole. It's onboard Intel graphics adapter lost out to the IBM T40's Radeon 7500. By the time we concluded the test, its bottom was a whopping 43 degree Celsius hot!

Given its configuration, the ACi Centrino is perfectly priced at Rs 89,990. Opt for it if you need a simple and elegant laptop and can put up with some heat!



ACi Centrino	C+				
Performance					
Features					
Usability					
Value for money					

Price: Rs 89,990
+ Sober looks, the latest hardware
- Gets heated up

ed by 512 MB of RAM (not that 256 MB won't work), return great results even under intensive and graphically heavy applications such as games. All the contenders, except the BPL Notebook, had DVD-CDRW combo drives, and nearly all of them came with a healthy reserve of 40 GB of hard drive space. Wireless connectivity is another boon of the Centrino platform, and it makes for one more option in addition to the normal Ethernet and modem.

Acer TravelMate 290

Beast outside, beauty inside

Already lacking in aesthetic appeal, the plastic grey body and huge dimensions of the Acer TravelMate 290 make it look even worse. The black keyboard inscribed with bold characters and the silver-lined touchpad breaks the otherwise bland grey plastic. A bigger keyboard would have suited the laptop rather than the small keyboard that leaves vast empty plastic panels for palm rest. The laptop is solidly put together and feels rugged.

Configuration-wise, it comprises an Intel Pentium M 1.4 GHz CPU, 256 MB DDR RAM, a 40 GB hard drive and a crisp 15-inch TFT LCD screen. The combo-drive is placed in front and is prone to popping when your fingers touch the eject button accidentally. There are no extra frills, say, Audio DJ, flash memory card readers, etc, to spoil you.

The Travelmate 290 performed well across the board. It was on par with most of the other notebooks in the CPU test. In the system-benchmarking test that used Business Winstone, it was only three units behind ACi Centrino and just 0.3 units behind the IBM T40. In *Quake III Arena*, it was on par with other systems, delivering a jerk-free frame rate even at the highest settings. The Intel onboard graphics controller definitely has enough power to run graphically demanding applications to certain extent. The batteries lasted for a little over 4 hours on par with the Wipro Little Genius.

For a product that has nearly everything you can expect from it, Rs 79,990 isn't too much to pay.



Acer TravelMate 290	
Performance	    
Features	    
Build quality	    
Value for money	    

Price: Rs 79,790
+ Good overall performance
- Bulky design